A COLLABORATIVE RESEARCH PROPOSITION / DISCUSSION DRAFT

The Political Economy of Imperial Accumulation

Theoretical, quantitative and historical inquiry into the constitution, reproduction and transformation of imperial relations

01 / The research problem

The research problem

Imperial accumulation is sustained through historically changing relations among production, circulation, political authority, territorial organisation and coercion. Marxist political economy has developed powerful, but differently constituted, explanations of colonial drain, worldwide value, unequal exchange, agrarian transformation and militarised destruction. These approaches identify processes that may be historically connected without being analytically equivalent.

The explanatory problem is to establish *how* those processes were connected in particular historical configurations, how their relationships reproduced imperial power, and under what conditions they were reorganised or challenged. A fiscal transfer, an international value relation and the destruction of productive capacity cannot be presumed to measure the same phenomenon. Nor can their historical interdependence be inferred merely by placing their accounts alongside one another.

The programme therefore investigates specific relationships among mechanisms, institutions and social struggles. Its working proposition is that reconstructing those relationships across different forms of evidence can refine existing explanations and generate questions that no initial approach fully specifies. The proposition must be demonstrated through substantive research, not assumed from the value of collaboration alone.

02 / Intellectual context and ongoing debates

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The programme engages ongoing debates within historical materialism and Marxist political economy. Samir Amin's work on unequal development and delinking, Walter Rodney's account of the production of underdevelopment, and Utsa and Prabhat Patnaik's reconstructions of colonial drain and imperial appropriation provide substantial explanations of the international organisation and reproduction of accumulation. Radhika Desai's geopolitical economy insists on the historically constituted relations among economic development, states, class struggle and international power.

Alan Freeman's work on temporal value determination and non-equilibrium Marxist economics, alongside his forthcoming *On the Law of Worldwide Value*, brings foundational questions of value, historical time and the international organisation of accumulation into the programme. Bikrum Gill's research on colonial land appropriation and the agrarian question, Jairus Banaji's historical investigation of categories of production, and Ali Kadri's analysis of war and de-development extend the range of relations requiring explanation.

The contested terrain is wider still: unequal exchange after Arghiri Emmanuel; dependency and super-exploitation in Ruy Mauro Marini; world-systemic accounts associated with Giovanni Arrighi; and research on global labour, labour arbitrage and embodied transfers by John Smith, Intan Suwandi, Jason Hickel and collaborators. These are not interchangeable theories or measures. Their differences are among the substantive questions a shared historical investigation can clarify. Their inclusion implies neither agreement nor confirmed participation.

03 / A methodological proposition: historical problems and theoretical development

A methodological proposition: historical problems and theoretical development

Marxist historical inquiry has long moved between concrete historical processes and theoretical abstraction. The programme builds on that tradition. Its proposed contribution is to organise *cumulative, collective investigation* across bodies of work whose objects, categories and evidentiary practices do not necessarily coincide.

Each inquiry begins with a specified historical problem and asks which relations must be reconstructed to explain it. Theoretical models, quantitative estimates, archival evidence and historical comparisons are brought into conversation as the investigation develops. Findings in one line of research may establish the limits of an account, revise the period or unit being studied, or pose a new question for another. These possibilities are to be established through research rather than promised in advance.

This also requires historicising categories and units of analysis: examining how such objects as colonial territories, national economies, monetary relations and political jurisdictions were themselves constituted and reorganised. The programme treats scale as a question of the territorial, institutional and economic reach of the relations under investigation, not as a fixed ladder from local to global.

04 / Historical problems as sites of inquiry

How the problem and approach might be investigated

Colonial India: drain, value relations and imperial reproduction. The Patnaiks' reconstruction of colonial drain provides an established account of the fiscal and export-surplus arrangements through which Britain appropriated Indian resources. An initial inquiry could examine a defined period of this process through land revenue, commodity production, trade settlement, colonial budgets and metropolitan finance, while asking how these arrangements relate to accounts of international value formation and unequal exchange. Do the approaches identify distinct but connected transfers, different dimensions of the same historical process, or processes whose relationship varies over time? The inquiry would specify the relevant evidence and measures before deciding which explanation is adequate. It begins from the Patnaiks' substantive historical work rather than treating it as a gap.

British North Borneo: commercial enterprise as territorial authority. The British North Borneo Chartered Company exercised governmental authority while pursuing commercial accumulation. This makes its administration a revealing site for examining how the distinctions between firm and state, fiscal extraction and production, and commercial infrastructure and coercive rule were historically constituted. Research on a specified district or period could trace land policy, revenue, plantation labour, transport and resistance, asking which relations sustained company rule and where they encountered limits. Comparisons with Malaya would require independent historical justification.

West Asia: war and the destruction of productive capacity. Building on Ali Kadri's work, an investigation of a specified period in Iraq or another setting could reconstruct the relationships among military destruction, sanctions where applicable, public finance, production and political authority. It would test how far accounts centred on appropriation, value relations and de-development explain the historical sequence, including processes not readily captured as commodity or financial transfers.

Indonesia: attempts to reorganise imperial relations. Post-independence Indonesia offers a possible investigation of transformation through struggles over economic sovereignty, foreign enterprises, nationalisation and the organisation of production. A focused historical study could ask which relations were materially altered, which persisted through new institutions, and how domestic political conflict and international pressures shaped the capacities to sustain change. Neither independence nor nationalisation is

assumed to constitute delinking: the extent and durability of transformation are the questions to be investigated.

05 / Proposed research intervention

Proposed research intervention

The initiative will organise small collaborative investigations around historically specified explanatory problems. A shared dossier will set out the historical sequence, the available archival and quantitative evidence, the competing or non-equivalent explanations, and the questions that remain unresolved. Participants can then identify what additional evidence, reconstruction or theoretical clarification is required.

An initial discussion could use colonial India to examine how fiscal appropriation, monetary settlement and international value relations were connected during a defined period. The aim is not to manufacture a dispute between existing accounts but to identify precisely what each explains, what it measures, and what further historical reconstruction would establish. Subsequent investigations could test the programme's reach in settings of corporate territorial rule, militarised destruction and attempted transformation.

Outputs may include jointly authored historical studies, documented quantitative reconstructions, theoretical papers and a developing comparative research agenda. The value of the programme will be judged by the substantive explanations it produces.

06 / Provisional research questions

Provisional research questions

Historical constitution: How have the economic, political and territorial relations through which imperial accumulation operates been constituted and reorganised? What does their history imply for the categories, boundaries and scales through which we investigate them?

Reproduction: How do these relations sustain and transform one another over time? Which institutions, infrastructures, forms of dependence and territorial divisions are necessary to their reproduction, and which are contingent or historically variable?

Transformation: What do crises, insurgencies, state projects and attempts to reorganise production reveal about the durability and vulnerability of imperial relations? How are the political and material capacities to change those relations produced, connected or destroyed?

Theoretical development: What new questions arise when different approaches investigate the same historical process in conversation with one another? How might their findings redirect the inquiry, develop existing explanations or generate new abstractions?

07 / Initial phase and invitation

Initial phase and invitation

An initial exploratory workshop of approximately six to eight researchers is proposed, organised around one pre-circulated historical dossier and a short set of questions for discussion. The participants, timing and first case remain open to collective decision. This prospectus is an invitation to shape the research, not a statement of theoretical consensus, confirmed participation or committed funding.

The independently developed Unequal Appropriation Toolkit may support documentation and reproducible quantitative work where useful. It does not supply the programme's theoretical foundation or determine participation.

References and related scholarship

Selected works and debates: Amin, *Accumulation on a World Scale* (1974); Banaji, *Theory as History* (2010); Desai, *Geopolitical Economy* (2013); Emmanuel, *Unequal Exchange* (1972, English edition); Gill, *The Political Ecology of Colonial Capitalism* (2024); Kadri, *Arab Development Denied* (2014); Patnaik and Patnaik, *Capital and Imperialism* (2021); Rodney, *How Europe Underdeveloped Africa* (1972).

Further relevant work includes Freeman, *Marx without Equilibrium* (1995), and *On the Law of Worldwide Value* (forthcoming; details to be confirmed); Freeman and Carchedi (eds), *Marx and Non-Equilibrium Economics* (1996); Marini, *Dialectics of Dependency*; Arrighi, *The Long Twentieth Century*; Smith, *Imperialism in the Twenty-First Century*; Suwandi, *Value Chains*; and recent empirical research by Hickel and collaborators on embodied labour and resource appropriation.